

THE ANCIENT WORLD

The ancient world is a jigsaw of images and objects that historians are trying to piece together. Paintings, sculpture, artefacts, and scraps of clothing and jewellery all provide clues as to how people lived and dressed. Many of the early civilizations reached impressive levels of development. Sophisticated technologies and craft skills coexisted in different corners of the world, as they still do today, and influenced each other as cultures met through war, exploration, and commercial exchange. Clothing and accessories – including protective armour and talismanic jewellery – were often produced to extremely high standards. Fine linen was woven on the banks of the Nile in Egypt; sericulture from China supplied the wider world with exquisite silks; the Greeks and Romans created fantastic wool tapestries; and the Etruscans crafted ornate, tooled metalwork.

Starting points

Many shapes and styles in dress date back thousands of years, having necessity, function, and the materials available as their starting points. For example, connecting two pieces of material to form a garment may once have meant no more than using a simple fastening such as a pin or a few basic stitches, but from such crude beginnings wonderful pieces of embroidery evolved, providing decoration and reinforcement at the same time. Embroidery on traditional dress from, say, Eastern Europe or southwest China is often concentrated around the neck, hem, shoulders, and wrist – the areas that are most visible and most subject to wear and tear.

Cycle of fashion

If the clothes people wore in the distant past often look remarkably modern and familiar, this is because of the way styles are continually revived and reinterpreted through cycles of history and waves of fashion. Modern designers have borrowed again and again from the styles – and style icons – of the past. Numerous examples can be listed of fashions that have had their day and gone, only to reappear with a new spin: the elegant draperies of classical Greek and Roman goddesses; Ancient Egypt’s massive jewellery and the kohl-eyed, black-bobbed “Cleopatra look”; Chinese and Japanese silks and sashes; exotic Near Eastern asymmetry and A-line cut garments; colourful, patterned textiles from India and southern Asia; and dynamic geometric, anthropomorphic patterns from pre-Columbian civilizations. From couture house to high street boutique, the modern fashion world owes much to the past.



TO 10,000BCE	10,000–4,000BCE	4,000–3,500BCE	
c.500,000–100,000BCE The first clothing, the hides of animals, are worn, sometimes tied on with beltlike strips of hide. ▼ Stripped buffalo hide	c.10,000BCE The earliest surviving shoes are sandals discovered in a cave in Oregon, woven from tree bark, fashioned at least 10,000 years ago. c.10,000BCE Wool cloth starts with the domesticated sheep, bred for soft wool as opposed to fur.	▼ Egyptian sandals c.4000BCE c.4,000BCE These thonged leather sandals, c. 6,000 years old, are part of daily wear in Ancient Egypt.	
	7500–5700BCE Dyed textiles are in use in Catal Höyük, southern Anatolia (present-day Turkey), as evidenced by traces of red dye, possibly ochre, found at the site.		
	7500–5700BCE Seals such as this one from the settlement of Catal Höyük, Turkey, are used during the Neolithic period to stamp decorative designs in dye onto skin or cloth. ► Neolithic baked clay seal		
c.40,000BCE People punch holes in skins and furs, lacing them together. The earliest bone needle dates to c.30,000 BCE.			
c.30,000BCE Cave painters use pigments such as ochre, hematite, and charcoal to colour their art, and probably to decorate their own bodies too. ► Prehistoric rock art, Acacus National Park, Libya			
		c.3,600BCE Flax is the predominant fibre used to create clothing in Egypt.	